



ALL TEAMS WERE EXPECTING TO PLAY THIS TOURNAMENT IN BANGLADESH, THE ORIGINAL HOST, WHICH LOST THE EVENT DUE TO DOMESTIC POLITICAL TURMOIL

back despite its bowling group's efforts.

In the 13 T20Is the team has played in 2024, it has won just one game — against England — and that too by a whisker (three runs). Its defeats have been fairly comprehensive, hardly the signs a side wants in a World Cup year.

With the odds stacked against them, it's understandable that the White Ferns have opted for experience over experimentation.

Outgoing skipper Devine and Sophie Bates, the steel pillars of New

Zealand cricket, will prop up the team on their shoulders for the ninth edition. From the Kerr sisters and Lea Tahuu to a returning Rosemary Mair, it's familiar faces all around. Keeper-batter Izzy Gaze is the only name to not have featured in a World Cup for the Kiwis before.

Their Trans-Tasman neighbours have taken a similar approach. Tough calls have been made, with senior pro Jess Jonassen missing out on a World Cup for the first time while being fit and available.

Sophie Molineux, whose stock as a shrewd spinner has risen exponentially after a famous WPL

triumph with Royal Challengers Bengaluru, will be key to Australia's fortunes. Allrounder Grace Harris will hope to devastate as much as she entertains, while Darcie Brown and Tayla Vlaeminck have made the cut to bolster their respective departments. Phoebe Litchfield is set for a debut World Cup.

All teams were expecting to play this tournament in Bangladesh, the original host, which lost the event due to domestic political turmoil. While the nation's cricket board has retained hosting rights, it will rue the missed opportunity to bring the best of the world to its lands after a decade, giving the game within its peripheries a shot in the arm.

The Bangladeshi side has played 12 T20Is this year, winning just two of them — against Thailand and

Malaysia in the Asia Cup. Skipper Nigar Sultana Joty continues to be the team's fulcrum for longer than she would have liked, and will desperately need her colleagues to step up with the bat if they are to compete well in this tournament.

A demand for better intent was underlined by chief selector Sajjad Ahmed when he defended dropping Rumana Ahmed for not showing enough aggression with the bat. This was one of the five changes from the country's Asia Cup squad.

Building blocks

Perennial batting woes aside, Bangladesh's strength continues to be its bowling. Seasoned pro Jahanara Alam made her way back into the setup during the Women's Asia Cup and is headed for her sixth T20 World Cup. She will hope to find her rhythm in a partnership with the young but versatile Marufa Akter.

With Fahima Khatun, Nahida Akter, and Co. on one side, and the young Shorna Akter on the other, there's a potent spin pool at Joty's disposal on surfaces that will eventually offer greater turn.

Bangladesh last played an international fixture in July, much like India, and has been



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